

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

INDIA-NEPAL - 2

MODULE - 23

CROSS-BORDER COOPERATION

- 1 In September 2019, PM Modi and PM Oli inaugurated the 69km cross-border oil product pipeline
- 2 The pipeline will run from state Indian Oil's terminal in north Bihar to Nepal Oil Corporation's depot in Narayani zone of southern Nepal.
- 3 The Motihari-Amlekhgunj oil pipeline project was first proposed in 1996
- 4 It is hoped to cement India-Nepal ties in the backdrop of China's growing influence and repair the trust deficit between the two countries.



CROSS-BORDER COOPERATION

- 5 This pipeline is the first example of connectivity in the field of trade and transit in South Asia
- 6 It will enable Nepal to import cleaner petroleum products from India at a lower cost because of reduced transportation cost.
- 7 India is Nepal's sole supplier of oil which is currently carried on tankers via road to the land-locked country. India currently supplies 1.3 million tonnes per annum of petro products to Nepal



RIVER WATER COOPERATION

- Numerous Himalayan rivers flowing into Nepal present significant opportunities for joint power project development for hydropower generation.

1 India and Nepal signed an Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) for construction of a new bridge over Mechi river at Indo-Nepal border. The Mechi river is a trans-boundary river tributary of the Mahananda river, flowing through Nepal and India.

2 The cost of construction of the bridge is Rs. 158.65 crore, which would be funded by India through Asian Development Bank (ADB) loan.

3 The bridge will improve regional connectivity and has potential to strengthen cross border trade between both the countries and cementing ties by strengthening industrial, social and cultural exchanges.



RIVER WATER COOPERATION

4 In May 2019, the Indian Cabinet approved ₹1236 crore investments for Arun-3 hydro project. The project will provide surplus power to India's strengthening economic linkages with Nepal.

5 India is looking to develop the inland waterways for the movement of cargo, within the framework of trade and transit arrangements, providing additional access to sea for Nepal calling it linking Sagarmath (Mt. Everest) with Sagar (Indian Ocean).



MULTILATERAL COOPERATION

1 India and Nepal share multiple multilateral forums such as BBIN (Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, and Nepal), BIMSTEC (Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation) NAM, and SAARC (South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation).

2 Nepal walked out of joint military exercises of BIMSTEC because of domestic political turmoil. The joint exercises focused on tactical level counter-terror operations.

3 The aim was to upgrade the relations from regional trade and connectivity to security issues. Nepal did it to maintain equidistance from neighbors and preserve its 'autonomous foreign policy'.



CULTURAL

- India boasts of civilizational ties with Nepal and the countries share deep linguistic and cultural similarity, religious affinity, historical ties and geographical proximity and family connections.
- India is leveraging its traditional ties and trying to convert them into opportunities, such as:

- 1 Important landmarks of Buddhism like Lumbini are located in Nepal, which are culturally significant for India.
- 2 The International Buddhist Circuit connecting Holy Sites of Buddhism
- 3 PM Modi inaugurated the Ramayana Circuit bus Route connecting Janakpur to Ayodhya.



CULTURAL

4 In 2019 Nepal issued three commemorative coins marking the 550th birth anniversary of founder of Sikhism Guru Nanak, who visited Kathmandu five hundred years ago.

5 The country also paid rich tributes to Mahatma Gandhi, marking his 150th birth anniversary.

TIGER CENSUS

- Indian and Nepal had agreed to collaborate on conducting the Tiger census in their countries in 2018, but yet to decide upon an agreement on sharing detailed assessments of the numbers.



CLIMATE CHANGE

- 1 Nepal has invited PM Modi to attend the first international Sagarmatha Sambaad forum to discuss issues of global, regional and national significance under the theme "Climate Change, Mountains and the Future of Humanity".
- 2 The event was scheduled for the first week of April but has been postponed considering the current world health crisis triggered by the COVID-19.
- 3 Sagarmatha, a Nepali name for the world's tallest mountain Qomolangma, while Sambaad refers to dialogue.



CLIMATE CHANGE

4 It aims to

- a** Forge a common consensus among countries on the climate crisis and
- b** Encourage political leaders to mobilise their political willpower to tackle its menace.
- c** Create awareness about the relation that exists between the climate change and mountain ecology.

5 The dialogue would bring together all stakeholders -global leaders, including heads of state/government, parliamentarians, policy makers and the civil society



PEOPLE TO PEOPLE

- 1** People-to-people contact between India and Nepal is deep and strong.
- 2** Nepal comprises large sections of Madhesi population which have familial and ethnic ties with states of Bihar and UP.
- 3** Nepalese labour takes care of labour scarcity in different parts of India because of the open border.
- 4** Presently, according to the Ministry of External Affairs, about 6 lakh Indians live in Nepal.
- 5** These include businessman and traders who have been living in Nepal for a long time, professionals like doctors, engineers and IT personnel and labourers in the construction sector.



PEOPLE TO PEOPLE

6 Indian citizens under 15 and over 65 travelling to Nepal and Bhutan do not need a visa if they have a valid passport, a photo identity card issued by the government of India or an election ID card by the Election Commission.

7 India provides scholarships to Nepali students, strengthening people-to-people contacts.



- There are several issues in the relationship which can be categorized into-
 1. Political and Strategic
 2. Territorial dispute
 3. Economic
 4. China factor



POLITICAL AND STRATEGIC

1 The treaty of Peace and Friendship is considered as **unequal** as Nepalese law does not permit an open border and Indians should not be able to buy lands and properties in Nepal.

2 The emergence of **Maoists** in Nepal and **India** are furthering bad sentiments.

3 In March **1989**, **India** decided to close all the **border transit points** in response to Chinese arms supplies is an example of Indian high-handedness.

4 Nepalese leaders asserted that as per the UN Charter, transit privileges were a 'fundamental and permanent right of a landlocked country'.



POLITICAL AND STRATEGIC

5 The Madhesis feel neglected by India as they feel India's Nepal policy prioritizes Kathmandu.

6 Nepal, between India and China, witnessed political instability for many years before the pro-China Left alliance came to power in December, 2017.

7 Water has been a contentious issue between India and Nepal because of the controversies surrounding water treaties on Kosi, Gandak and Mahakali.



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